by a combined margin of only 22,779 votes across eight constituencies. The Congress leader presented granular data as evidence to support his claim that fake votes were engineered to turn the BJP's defeat into victory. He showcased ECI–certified pages where the photograph of a Brazilian model appeared 22 times in the Rai constituency under different names, calling it the most glaring example of fake voting. He also presented documents indicating 521,000 duplicate voters, 93,174 invalid addresses, and 1.9 million bulk voters registered at addresses with over 20 people each.

Rahul also alleged cross-state voter duplication, claiming thousands of voters, including BJP-linked sarpanches from Mathura district, were listed in both UP and Haryana rolls. Referring to large-scale deletions, he asserted that 350,000 voters, about 2 per cent of the electorate, were removed between the LS and assembly polls.

EC'S REBUTTAL

As in August when Rahul cited data to show manipulation in Karnataka's Mahadevapura segment (Bengaluru Central LS seat) in the 2024 general election, within hours, ECI sources sought to brush aside the latest allegations, saying there had been no appeals/formal objections filed against Haryana's electoral rolls before the polls. Out of 90 constituencies, only 22 election petitions were pending in the Punjab and Haryana High Court, the ECI sources said. An election petition can be filed within 45 days of the announcement of results in the HC.

In response, Rahul has challenged the ECI to share CCTV footage of the voting booths, a demand the poll body has so far declined to entertain on the grounds of protecting voter privacy. In December 2024, the Centre had amended Rule 93(2)(a) of the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, on the EC's recommendation, restricting public access to election-related documents, including electronic records such as CCTV footage, webcasting data and video recordings. Critics called it a blow to electoral transparency.

Rahul alleges that the ECI's data-sharing system prevents timely scrutiny. Parties get voter lists "at the last moment" and in fragmented booth-level PDFs, not as searchable, machine-readable data. Without consolidated digital files, statewide anomalies like duplicate or bulk voters can't be detected in the short window before polls. While parties receive soft copies—PDFs or data CDs—through district agents and can track booth-level changes on the ERO-Net portal, many ex-election commissioners agree that providing statewide, machine-readable data could enhance transparency; as former chief election commissioner S.Y. Quraishi notes, it could help detect anomalies more effectively.

Most experts argue that the poll body must not brush aside these allegations just because they were not raised before the polls. "The specific instances cited merit a point-by-point response. Any other explanation will only hurt the credibility of the ECI. Technically, their stand may be correct, but it is not convincing," says former election commissioner Ashok Lavasa.

A HARYANA HURRICANE

- Rahul alleges 2.5 million Haryana voters were 'fake', helped BJP win '24 state poll
- ECI says no formal plaint; Cong. argues time window too short for full review
- ECI's credibility under question. Ex-CECs say suo motu inquiry warranted
- Cong. says legal recourse now procedural trap, pushing for trial in public court
- Rahul's charges give legitimacy to SIR exercise, for it seeks to clean up voter rolls

THE SIR DILEMMA

Ironically, the ECI's ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR)—the second phase of which began a day before Rahul's presser—was designed to address exactly these issues. Conducted first in Bihar recently, the SIR is a house-to-house verification drive to remove duplicate, dead, migrated or illegitimate voters while enrolling new ones. In Bihar, the process trimmed the rolls to 74.2 million, a purge of 4.7 million names, and now it has been extended to 12 states and UTs, including poll-bound Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Puducherry and West Bengal.

But what the ECI sees as an audit, the Congress calls an instrument of manipulation. At the press meet, Rahul even presented four individuals from Bihar whose names were deleted from the rolls despite possessing valid documents. On November 2, 44 Opposition parties decided to challenge the SIR in the Supreme Court, calling it "anti-democratic". The Bihar SIR, too, had faced a challenge in the SC over its timing and methodology, but the court allowed it to proceed after modifications, including accepting Aadhaar as valid voter identification.

On 'vote *chori*' in Haryana, Rahul is unwilling to move courts. Congress insiders call legal action a time-consuming trap, preferring public mobilisation over prolonged litigation. "We challenged the SIR in Bihar, but gained little," says a party general secretary, framing the fight as one between institutional capture and public conscience. That was Rahul's closing plea, too. Calling the Haryana and Maharashtra governments "illegitimate", he appealed to Gen Z to act, evoking youth-led movements in Bangladesh and Nepal as models of democratic renewal beyond courts and commissions.

As of now, the Congress leader's allegations strike at the core of electoral credibility, while the ECI's defence invokes procedural propriety. Between these competing narratives lies a larger question: can democratic faith endure when trust in the referee itself is contested? ■